‘Now?’ I had to ask. Sunset was edging closer as we spoke. To prepare the helicopter, to add fuel to it, get clearances for flying and go to Kargil and then come back was a lot to do in this little time.

‘There was an air strike at the enemy supply dumps and a few posts this morning. Damage assessment needs to be done. The army can’t go there, since the enemy is sitting at a higher altitude. So we have been asked to do it.’

He paused for a while, looked at his wristwatch and said, ‘Sunset is only three hours away. Meet me in the briefing room. We’re racing against time.’

This recce sortie was the need of the hour. Wing Commander Srivastav told me and the other male pilot during the briefing that the army was supposed to launch further offensives the next morning with the aim of capturing Tololing, and all plans for these would depend on the degree of damage caused by the air strikes. The Tololing Top, a dominant position overlooking the Srinagar–Leh highway (NH-1D), was a vital objective, the capture of which could change the course of war. And if not fought off, the enemy could cut off the army’s only supply route to Kargil. Since the start of the Battle of Tololing on 20 May 1999, we had lost many soldiers, including air force personnel. An Mi-17 helicopter was shot down on 28 May near Tololing by a Pakistani surface-to-air missile, which had resulted in the martyrdom of four air warriors.

The helicopter we were flying was not clear to fly in the hills after sunset. And the sun in the hills sets earlier than in the plains, owing to the terrain. As per rules, in plains, a pilot is supposed to land half an hour prior to sunset, and only if he/she is flying at their base where they’re familiar with the terrain, are they given a special clearance to fly until sunset. Since Srinagar was not our base, we had to land half an hour prior to sunset, and that, too, after hill correction time was added to it. This left us with less than three hours to perform our recce.

Of the male pilot and me, the flight commander asked me to be his co-pilot that evening. I was sincerely hoping for him to choose me as I didn’t want to sit there whiling away time and overthinking.